> In the year 1906 some of the merchants of Tuticorin who were troubled and harassed very much by the British India Steam Navigation Company wanted to establish a Swadeshi steamer service between Tuticorin and Colombo and they asked me to join with them and work. I thought it was a laudable enterprise and would benefit the country very much, so I gave up my practice as a Second Grade Pleader and joined with them and started the Company. In the beginning we chartered some steamers and conducted the service for about six months.[12]

This statement is factual and not argumentative—understandable given the context it was made in. But VOC provides a somewhat more detailed version of the origins of the Swadeshi company in his verse autobiography, written in Coimbatore prison when he was incarcerated there between July 1908 and December 1910. Given the constraints of the verse form, the narrative is allusive and open to interpretation. That he was a prisoner when he wrote and would have feared self-incrimination should also be factored in. The following is a paraphrase of the relevant portion of the autobiography.[13]

VOC followed the newspapers closely and kept himself abreast of happenings in the outside world. Even before his move to Tuticorin, he had travelled to Madras City and to Trivandrum more than once. News of the partition of Bengal and the rise of the Swadeshi movement soon reached him. VOC attributed his early initiation into Swadeshism to his encounter with Swami Ramakrishnananda, a direct disciple of the ascetic saint Ramakrishna Paramahansa. VOC had met him in Madras City, where he was based for fourteen years from the inauguration of the Ramakrishna Mission until a little before his death in 1911. At this meeting, Swami Ramakrishnananda ‘sowed the seed of Swadeshism in my [VOC’s] heart’. This was sometime in late 1905. Soon, in November–December, two Bengalis—unfortunately, VOC does not provide names—appeared together ‘like cloud and thunder’, met him at Tuticorin on their way to Japan and ‘poured like sweet rains the message of growing Swadeshism in Bengal’.

Following this, VOC writes that he started three Swadeshi organizations: a weaving factory, a shipping line and a Swadeshi emporium. Of the three ventures, it was the shipping line that attracted the most criticism from his